



New city, same Lewangoalski: Fire's new star scores his first MLS goals

The Fire defeated Charlotte 2-1 in the Polish striker's home debut.

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Under the bright lights of Soldier Field, Robert Lewandowski etched his name on a Major League Soccer score sheet for the first time, leading the Chicago Fire to a 2-1 victory against Charlotte FC on Aug. 1, 2026.

Charlotte midfielder Pep Biel put his team ahead with a goal 18 minutes in, but his celebrations were cut short. Two minutes later, Fire forward Philip Zinckernagel headed a ball to Lewandowski, who took two touches and slotted it in the back of the net from outside of the box.

The goal was the Polish striker's first in a Fire kit after being held scoreless in his two previous appearances against New York City FC and Inter Miami CF. Lewandowski's goal ignited thousands of Fire fans in the stadium, many of whom already had his jersey on their backs and a Polish flag in their hands.

Among those in attendance was Victoria Pundyk, a Polish fan who held a sign that asked for Lewandowski's shirt.

"It was my first time ever seeing him in person, and it was cool to see him score," Pundyk said.

She has always watched Lewandowski play for Poland's national team and loved experiencing the atmosphere in person among other Polish fans.

As both teams sought after a goal to put them ahead, Chicago stayed put together offensively. Fire goalkeeper Chris Brady, who recently returned from FIFA World Cup international duty with the United States Men's National Team, didn't need to make any saves.



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Robert Lewandowski celebrates his first Major League Soccer goal with his Chicago Fire FC teammates as Charlotte FC goalkeeper takes the ball out of the net at Soldier Field on Aug. 1, 2026. Lewandowski accepted a two-year contract with the Fire in June 2026.



A young Chicago Fire fan poses for a photo holding a sign welcoming Robert Lewandowski to Chicago that says the Polish striker is his favorite player at Soldier Field on Aug. 1, 2026. The crowd featured fans of all ages eager to see Lewandowski play in Chicago for the first time. (Isabella Siemaszko)

In the 68th minute, Lewandowski chipped a shot past Charlotte goalkeeper Kristijan Kahlina to score the eventual game-winning goal.

As Lewandowski, the former Bayern Munich and FC Barcelona player, finished hugging his new teammates, he turned to Fire supporters to do his trademark goal celebration. They roared and clapped in return. Draping over the stands, a banner that read “Welcome Lewy” served as a backdrop to the scene.

In a post-match press conference, Lewandowski said he was happy with the win and with his goals.

“The first goals always feel special, just as they have throughout my entire career,” he said. “Every first goal at a new club, it’s always dedicated to my dad, who’s surely watching over me from up there somewhere.”

Commenting on his fitness, the striker noted that he feels he’s still in “pre-season” form.

“With each day and week, I’ll definitely keep improving physically,” Lewandowski said. “Today, after three weeks, it felt better. My legs carried me more, and I think you could see that on the field.”

Lewandowski became a free agent in June 2026, when his contract with Barcelona expired. After four seasons, 119 goals, five trophies – including three La Liga titles – and a Pichichi, the now 37-year-old decided to close the chapter on his decorated European club career.

The Fire, who’ve had their sights set on the player for over a year, did everything they could to make sure that the Windy City found itself at the top of Lewandowski’s list. Shortly after a visit with the club in July, he signed a two-year contract with the Men in Red.

Łukasz Chodorowski, a long time Polish Fire fan, said he’s incredibly happy that Lewandowski joined the club because it “means a lot for most of the Polish nation.”



“Chicago has one of the largest Polish communities in the U.S.,” Chodorowski said. “It’s like we’ve been re-inspired and we want to celebrate for him. Lewangowski is a great player and I want him to get as many trophies as possible.”

After officially announcing his choice to join the MLS side, Lewandowski made clear that his decision wasn’t solely based on the financial package offered.

“I was impressed by how the club tried to recruit me, by the project they presented, and by the direction they want to take,” he said.

Prior to signing for Barcelona, Lewandowski scored 344 goals in 375 appearances over eight seasons with Bayern, where he won 19 titles, including one Champions League. He also won Bundesliga titles with Borussia Dortmund in 2011 and 2012 after making his name in Poland with Lech Poznań.

After the game against Charlotte, Fire coach Gregg Berhalter acknowledged that the team still has a lot to figure out. But he said he was happy that Lewandowski was able to make a big mark on the game.

“He’s dynamic and he’s smart and he’s clever and he sees the game, reads the game very well,” Berhalter said. “He’s an absolute killer and I think this is the beginning of hopefully a lot of goals.”

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